Age-related effects on the acquisition of L2 collocational knowledge

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Abstract: The role of age-related factors in second language acquisition (SLA) has long been a central focus of theoretical inquiry and empirical investigation. While extensive research has explored age effects on second language (L2) phonological and morphosyntactic development, the acquisition of collocational knowledge – critical for oral and written proficiency yet notoriously challenging for learners – remains underexplored. Collocations, as conventionalized word combinations, exhibit slow development with advancing age and may be uniquely sensitive to the timing of L2 instructional onset. To bridge this gap, the present study examines the effects of biological age and age of onset (AO) on L2 collocational knowledge among Chinese English learners. Collocational knowledge is operationalized as the number of collocational responses generated in a word association task, with collocates identified using the Log Dice metric. A total of 176 participants, drawn from first-year (younger age group) and third-year (older age group) university students, were categorized into early AO (starting before Grade 3) and late AO (starting after Grade 3) groups based on national curricular standards. Results showed that although the older group produced slightly more collocational responses than the younger group, the difference was not statistically significant. Instead, early AO learners generated significantly more collocational responses than late AO learners. A two-way ANOVA confirmed a significant main effect of AO, with no significant effect of age or interaction between

age and AO. These findings suggest that the starting age of L2 learning plays a more crucial role in the acquisition of L2 collocational knowledge than biological age. The advantage observed in early AO learners may be attributed to their prolonged exposure to the target language and the cumulative effect of earlier lexical processing mechanisms. In contrast, the absence of a significant age effect indicates that the amount of intensive learning alone does not substantially enhance collocational knowledge acquisition at the tertiary level.

Keywords: Age of onset; collocational knowledge; word association task; second language acquisition